The singing staircase

Level 1 · Lesson 1 · listening, singing and feeling the pulse

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For: ages 8 to 12, the whole class. **Length:** 50 minutes.

Main objective: by the end of the lesson, each pupil, first in a group and then in pairs, adjusts their voice until they sing the same note the keyboard plays, and the tuner shows the same note name.

Secondary objectives: (1) show with the hand whether the music goes up or down; (2) keep the pulse with claps while the staircase is playing.

What you need: a computer with speakers and, if available, a projector. **No music knowledge needed:** the keyboard and the tuner do the work; you guide.

Before the lesson (15 minutes, at home): practise the keyboard. In class your attention needs to be on the children, not on the buttons. Repeat these steps until you can do them without looking at the guide:

- Open the Cosmic Keyboard and play `Z` `X` `C` `V` `B` `N` `M`: this is the scale from C to B.
- Open the **RECORDINGS** (☰ **recs**) list and play Bach's "Sinfonia No. 1".
- Open the metronome with **pulse**, set about 60 BPM with **tap**, press **start** and switch on **click**; close it with ⊗ (see "Before we start: the pulse").
- Open the tuner, allow the microphone, play a note on the keyboard and sing it: check whether the tuner shows the same name.

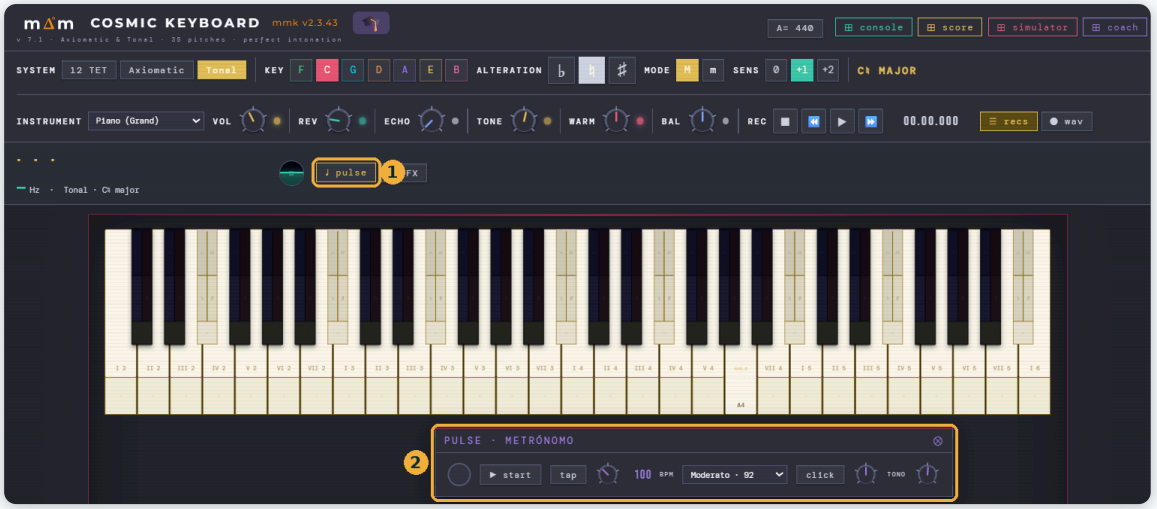
Before we start: the pulse

What is the pulse?

The pulse is the steady heartbeat of music: always the same distance apart, like the tick-tock of a clock or footsteps when walking. When we clap along to a song, we are clapping the pulse. Everyone who plays or sings together follows the same pulse.

The **metronome** is the machine that marks that heartbeat with a light and a sound, so the class stays together. Its speed is measured in **BPM**, beats per minute: **60 BPM = one beat per second**. More BPM, faster.

Where to find it on the Cosmic Keyboard



1. **Open the metronome:** press the **pulse** button (1), the one with a small musical note, in the third row from the top, next to **FX**.
2. The **PULSE · METRONOME** panel (2) appears below the keyboard.



3. **Choose the tempo** (the speed of the pulse). The easiest way: press **tap** several times in a row, at the speed you want; the metronome measures it and shows the **BPM**. You can also turn the **knob** next to tap: it raises or lowers the BPM, and the list shows the musical name of that tempo (for example *Andante · 76* or *Moderato · 92*). Or choose a tempo directly from the list. To begin, slowly: about **60 BPM**.
4. **Start it** with **start**. The **light** (the circle) flashes on every beat.
5. **To hear it,** switch on **click**. The two knobs on the right adjust the click: the first, its **volume**; the **TONE** knob, whether it sounds higher or lower.
6. **To close it,** press ⊗, at the top right of the panel.

The lesson, step by step

The lesson follows five stages: the goal, what they already know, the new material, the application and the review of the goal. **In each activity, you do it first and the class follows you.**

1 The goal

3 min

Tell the class, in these words or similar ones:

"Today we are going to make our voice sound exactly like a note on the keyboard. At the end, every pair will show it."

Write the goal on the board: **My voice sings the keyboard's note.**

2 What they already know

5 min

"Who sings at home? Can your voice sound higher and lower?"

First, you sing an "oo" that slides up from low to high as your hand rises, and slides down as your hand falls. Then the class does it with you.

3 New material: listening with the body, and the staircase

12 min

In **RECORDINGS** press ▶ on Bach's "Sinfonia No. 1". Listen to it three times, each time with a task. Show the movement yourself for a few seconds and then the class follows you:

1. **March on the spot** with the pulse.
2. **Draw the melody in the air** with the hand: if it goes up, the hand goes up; if it goes down, the hand goes down.
3. **"We're home!"**: when the music sounds as if it has arrived home (an ending that comes to rest), everyone stands up.

Then **the staircase**: play `Z` `X` `C` `V` `B` `N` `M` slowly, one key at a time. Sing each note yourself on a long "ah"; the second time, the class sings with you; the third time, the class sings alone. Then from the top down.

4 Application: the keyboard's note

25 min

Open the tuner and, if you can, project it so everyone can see it.

1. **Listen first.** Play a note from the staircase that is neither very high nor very low. Everyone listens in silence, without singing.
2. **Then adjust together.** The whole class sings the note on a long, soft "ah". With your hand you show "a little higher" or "a little lower", and everyone watches the tuner until it shows the same note name.
3. **Smaller and smaller groups:** the whole class, half the class, groups of about 10, pairs and, at the end, volunteers on their own. Nobody sings alone unless they want to.
4. **The echo:** when a note comes out well, play two notes in a row and then three. The class sings them back.
5. **The pulse** (the last 5 minutes): open the metronome at about 60 BPM. The class claps the pulse while you play the staircase, one key per beat. To finish, a volunteer plays the staircase following the pulse.

"Who can sing exactly the same note as the keyboard?"

5 Reviewing the goal

5 min

Go back to the sentence on the board. Each pair sings the note you play; the class watches the tuner and gives a thumbs-up if it matches.

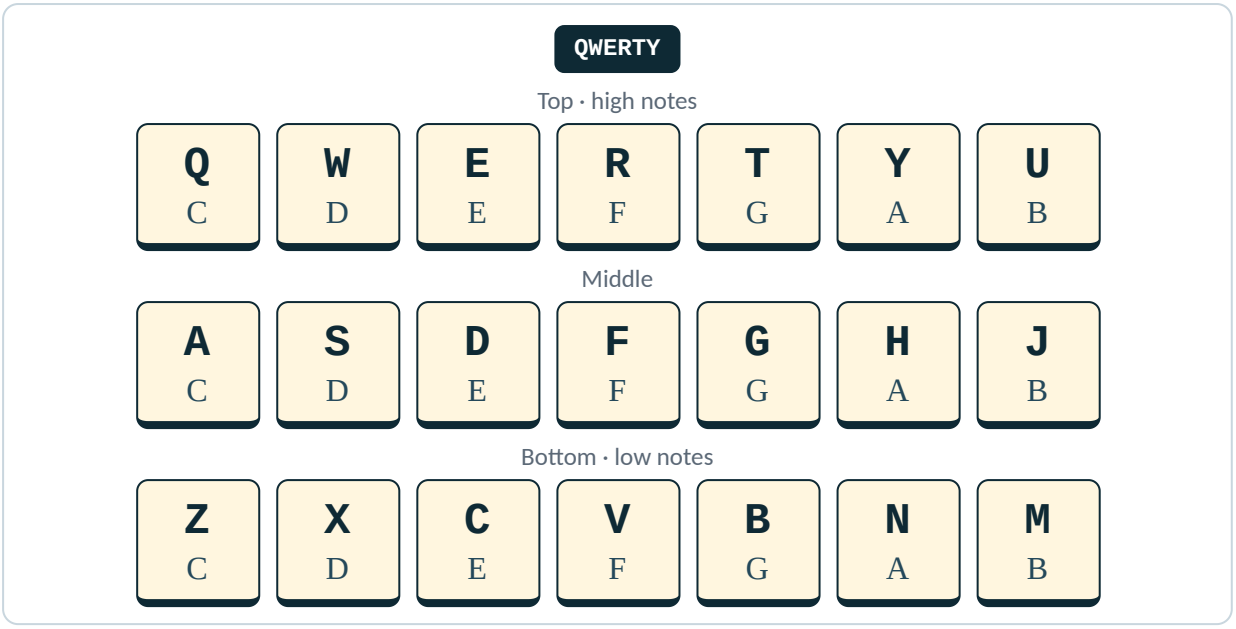
"What helped us bring our voice closer to the note?"

Listen to the answers: listening before singing, singing softly, following the hand, singing next to a classmate.

If they find it hard:

- **The class does not reach the note:** play it again, sing it with them and ask them to sing more softly. Your hand shows them whether to go up or down.
- **A child sings far from the note:** this is normal at this age. Let them keep singing in the group, next to a classmate who finds it. Do not correct them in front of everyone.
- **The tuner jumps from one note to another:** ask for a long, steady "ah", without shouting, close to the microphone, and silence from the rest of the class.
- **The pulse gets lost:** lower the tempo and have them march on the spot before going back to clapping.

The keys and their notes



The three rows of the computer keyboard have the same staircase, from C to B: the bottom row is the lowest and the top row the highest. The ← and → arrow keys change the octave: the whole staircase goes down or up.

Note names: *C = Do · D = Re · E = Mi · F = Fa · G = Sol · A = La · B = Si. Some materials use the syllables: both name the same note.*

How to tell it worked: in the review, at least three out of four pairs sing the note and the tuner shows the same name. In addition, most pupils show with their hand when the music goes up or down, and the class keeps the pulse with claps through the whole staircase.

These lessons are a starting point. Each teacher can design the examples to suit their own class. For our part, we will keep adding lesson topics according to the requests we receive through the contact form.

✂ cut out and take home

Let’s play with music at home

For parents · 10 minutes a week · no music knowledge needed

> **Why these games.** Just as your child learns to read and write words at school, in these lessons they begin to read and write music: a small grammar of sounds. Almost all of us listen to music all our lives without being able to read it; these ten minutes a week are so that this can begin to change at home too. No music knowledge needed: just play together.

Today in class we learned to sing the notes of the keyboard and to feel the pulse. This week, play together:

Z	X	C	V	B	N	M
C	D	E	F	G	A	B

Each key on the bottom row is a note, from C (the first) to B (the seventh).

1. Open the keyboard on the computer: **musicmotionsuite.com/apps/mmk-demo.html**
2. **The echo:** one person plays a key between `Z` and `M`; the other sings it. Then swap.
3. **The tuner:** the child sings a long note in front of **tuner.mariomaurano.com** and looks at its name. Can they sing the same note as the keyboard?
4. **The kitchen pulse:** put on one of the keyboard’s recordings (the **RECORDINGS** list, ☰ **recs** button). Each person chooses how to mark the pulse: one claps, the other stamps their feet or taps a wooden spoon on a saucepan. Can you stay together until the end?

The microphone works only on your computer: nothing is recorded or sent. No registration needed.

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